

Catching them YOUNG

To woo India's 100 million first time voters, politicians go in for a smarter, cleverer campaign

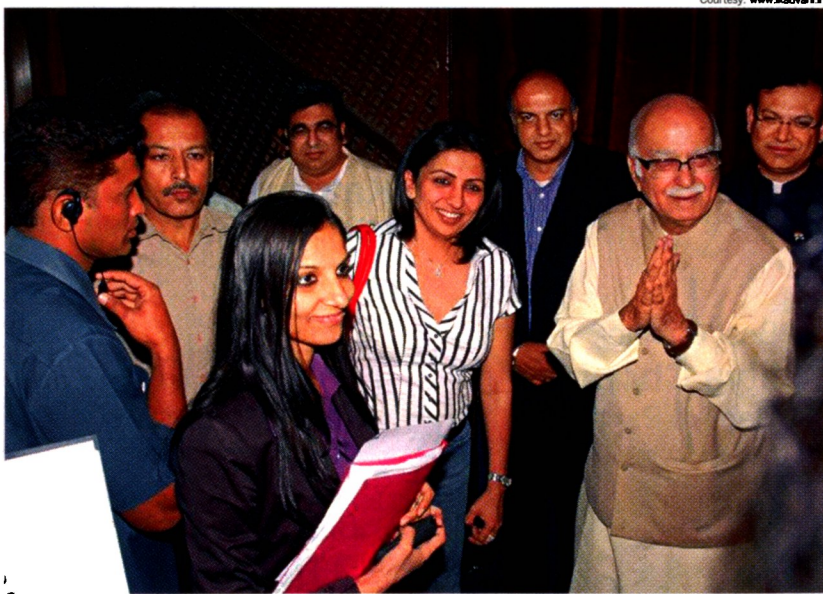
| By Priya Sahgal |

This is the age of Barack Obama where to be young is to embody change. It is not just enough to be biologically young but rather ideologically young enough to capture the youthful imagination. And so an 81-year-old L.K. Advani is rushing around playing hi-tech games, launching trendy websites, meeting IIM graduates and talking about his visit to the Microsoft Headquarters in Seattle. The 61-year-old Lalu Yadav does one better. He teaches management to IIM and Harvard University students. The 71-year-old Sheila Dikshit, living up to her persona as the neighbourhood's favourite 'aunty' throws open the lawns of her bungalow to school children and walks them through the flora and the fauna. As a Congress chief ministerial candidate in the recent Madhya Pradesh elections said while leaning precariously out his SUV to shake hands with some kids running alongside, "future voters".

It is a huge vote bank—a 100 million first-time voters for E-2009. As much as two-thirds of India's population is under 35. They're young, they're restless and they're old enough to vote. According to a BJP survey, each constituency comprises as much as 15 per cent of first-time voters. The party has instructed its state units to hold first-time voter camps and 'educate' the uncommitted as most have not yet decided.

Sheila Dikshit and Narendra Modi have already proved that age is merely a number. About 70 per cent of Delhi's 40 lakh first-time voters voted for Dikshit because her ideas on development and governance appealed to them. The 58-year-old Modi's campaign in Gujarat two years ago, merged hi-tech with governance and was an instant hit with the youth. To the netizens he is known as NaMo and his website attracts students who question him about three things: the education system, employment and terror. All are new age issues.

In the age of the Third Generation



Courtesy: www.lkadvani.in



YASHBANT NEGI

ADVANI INTERACTS WITH IIM STUDENTS (ABOVE) WHILE DIKSHIT INVITES STUDENTS HOME EVERY WEEK